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SPEY ELITE CASTING CLINIC

Module One — Foundations through Advanced Spey

Student Lesson Plan — 14-Hour (Weekend)

This handout follows both days of the weekend clinic. Use it to take notes, complete self-checks, and record your before/after video observations.

FOUNDATION	SWITCH	SPEY	ADVANCED
Lever physics · Anchor drills · In/Out of power	Switch Cast · Forward Spey · Waltz timing	Snap C/T · Single · Double	Snake Roll · Flying A · Film analysis

Name: ____	**Date:** ____
THE TWO RULES — ALWAYS: **Rule 1: What the rod tip does, the line does.** **Rule 2: Don't forget Rule 1.**	**IN POWER vs. OUT OF POWER:** Out of power: body rotation · arms follow · no loop intent. In power: arms only · body stopped · straight tip path.

DAY 1 — Steps 1–7

1	Foundation	Lever Physics, Two-Handed Rod Mechanics & Line Selection	55 min

C U E

KEY CUE

- Leverage is not strength — it is geometry. The lower hand is the power; the upper hand is the fulcrum.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Class levers and the rod: a first-class lever has the fulcrum between the effort and the load (seesaw). A third-class lever has the effort between the fulcrum and the load (broom). Single-handed fly rods operate primarily as third-class levers — the hand is the fulcrum, the lower grip is the effort, the rod tip is the load
- Two-handed rods shift this dynamic: the upper hand becomes the fulcrum around which the lower hand levers the rod. The lower hand — further from the tip — generates tremendous leverage with minimal effort. This is the defining mechanical advantage of the two-handed rod
- Leverage vs. speed: leverage generates power with economy of effort. Speed generates distance through acceleration. Two-handed rods excel at leverage; single-handed rods excel at speed. Understanding which you are generating at each moment determines efficient Spey casting
- The fulcrum principle: push with the upper hand, pull with the lower — simultaneously — during the forward stroke. The rod bends between those two forces and delivers energy to the line. Overpower with the upper hand and efficiency collapses
- All Spey casts can be made with a single-handed rod — the mechanics are identical. The two-handed rod offers reach, leverage economy, and line-weight capacity, not fundamentally different technique

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Lever demonstration: students hold the rod with upper hand fixed (fulcrum) and lower hand pushing/pulling — feel the mechanical advantage vs. a single-hand grip
- In power vs. out of power exercise: student raises rod slowly (out of power, body rotation) then executes a sharp forward roll (in power, arm motion only) — feel the transition
- Line comparison: cast a weight-forward taper for a roll cast, then a double taper — student describes the difference in load feel and anchor formation

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

2	Foundation	Fixed Anchor Drills — The Rod In and Out of Power	45 min

C U E

KEY CUE

- The line wants to follow the rod. The fixed anchor drill proves it. Stop fighting.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The fixed anchor drill: tie the fly line to a bottle or stake at rod-tip length. The line is now fixed. Student attempts to wiggle, oscillate, and move the line with the rod — they discover immediately that almost no effort is required. The line responds to the rod's movement with almost no force applied
- This drill eliminates the most universal error in Spey casting: muscling. Students who fight the line with brute force are fighting themselves. The fixed anchor makes the line's sensitivity visible and physical
- In-power: the rod tip travels in as straight a line as possible. The intent is loop formation. Arm motion drives this. Body rotation is complete before arm motion begins in the power phase
- Out-of-power: the rod is repositioning the line — sweeps, lifts, D-loop formation. Body rotation drives this phase. The tip path during out-of-power phases matters only in relation to where the line needs to go — not for loop shape
- The transition: most Spey casting problems live at the transition between out-of-power setup and in-power delivery. Students rush the transition, carry tension from the sweep into the roll, or fail to separate body rotation from arm motion

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Fixed anchor oscillation: tie line to stake, student oscillates rod gently — observe how little effort creates large movement in the line
- In-power isolation: without a fixed anchor, student makes small forward rolls using arm motion only with body stopped — observe loop formation
- Out-of-power sweep: student sweeps the rod from downstream to upstream using only body rotation, arms passive — observe the line moving without loop formation
- Transition drill: sweep out-of-power, stop body, fire in-power — 10 repetitions slow, then at natural speed

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

3	Switch	Switch Cast / Forward Spey / Forward Jump Roll — Three Names, One Cast	50 min

C U E

KEY CUE

- Say the words while you cast. Lift — Cut the trees — Climb the banana — GO.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The names: Switch Cast (two-handed), Forward Spey (alternative), Forward Jump Roll (single-handed equivalent) — these are the same cast in different traditions. We teach one movement, not three
- What it is: a D-loop cast made with a single repositioning movement. The line sweeps out of the dangle, the D-loop forms, and the forward cast fires. No change of direction — the cast goes back the way the line came
- Out-of-power phase: body rotation drives the line up and away from the water. Arms follow the body. No loop formation intent
- D-loop formation: the sweep climbs at 45 degrees and 'sets the anchor' — the fly and a small section of leader touch down just ahead of the caster's position. The D-loop hangs behind the rod tip
- In-power phase: arm motion only fires the forward roll. The body is already stopped. Push-pull with both hands delivers a tight roll

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Powell sequence recital: students say each step out loud as they perform it — 10 consecutive casts with verbal recitation
- Tiger sequence recital: Christopher Rownes' five steps — same protocol, verbal and physical simultaneously
- Waltz timing drill: instructor counts 1-2-3 for each phase — student matches the count with the cast movement
- Recital without rod: students perform the Glenda Powell sequence as pantomime, reciting the words — build muscle memory before adding the rod

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

4	Spey	Snap C — Commit & Complete, Anchor Placement	45 min

C U E

KEY CUE

- Commit. Complete. Two words, two movements, one anchor placed exactly where you want it.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Snap C is the gateway to repositioning casts. It belongs to the downstream wind family — used when the wind is upstream of the caster, or when a large change of direction is needed with a shooting head or Skagit setup
- Commit & Complete: 'Commit' describes the first movement — the rod is raised and moved upstream with commitment and direction, like a firm intention. 'Complete' describes the flip — the tip accelerates in a C-shaped arc back downstream and into the near bank, placing the line upstream as the anchor. These two words replace long technical descriptions with kinesthetic cues
- The C path: the rod tip traces a backward C (for a right-handed caster fishing from the left bank). The first half of the C raises the line; the second half flips the anchor upstream. The shape of the C determines where the anchor lands

- Anchor placement: the anchor (fly + short section of leader) should land 1–1.5 rod lengths upstream and slightly toward the target. Too far upstream = over-anchored (too much water tension). Too close = under-anchored (D-loop collapses). The Commit & Complete language helps students calibrate both
- What follows the Snap C: once the anchor is placed, the caster sweeps the rod tip upstream (the body-rotation, out-of-power phase), the D-loop forms, and the forward roll fires. The Snap C is only the setup — it is not itself a complete cast

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Commit & Complete recital: students say 'commit' as the rod rises, 'complete' as the tip traces the C — 10 repetitions, verbal and physical
- Anchor placement scoring: mark a target zone on the water 1 rod-length upstream — student scores each anchor landing (inside/outside/on target)
- Under-anchored vs. over-anchored demonstration: instructor intentionally produces both to make the visual difference clear before students practice
- Snap C to forward roll: chain the anchor placement with the D-loop sweep and delivery — 5 complete cast sequences

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

5	Spey	**Snap T — Upstream Wind, Direction Changes & Heavy Fly Application**	40 min

CUE

KEY CUE

- Snap T: the T is the path. Rise straight, snap perpendicular. The line follows the tip.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Snap T complements the Snap C — while the C traces a curved arc, the T makes a direct, perpendicular snap. The rod tip rises upstream on a straight line, then snaps down sharply in a T-shaped motion, flipping the anchor to the upstream side
- Upstream wind application: the Snap T — like the Snap C — places the anchor upstream of the caster, keeping the D-loop on the upstream (safe) side in upstream wind. Preferred for most upstream wind scenarios
- Heavy fly and sink tip advantage: the T's more direct snap generates a sharper lifting impulse that better lifts heavy flies and dense sink tips from the water. This is the Snap T's primary practical advantage over the Snap C
- Skagit system preference: Skagit heads (short, dense, heavy) are specifically designed for snap cast setups. The Snap T's short, sharp motion suits short head lengths. Long belly Spey lines require a longer, more progressive snap to avoid over-anchoring
- The T shape: the upward stroke (vertical) and the downward snap (horizontal) form the T. The snap happens at the junction — the rod changes direction sharply. The tip should not go above head height on the initial rise

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- T-shape tracing: draw the T motion in the air with the rod tip — vertical rise, pause, horizontal snap. 10 repetitions without line
- Snap T with floating line: execute the full Snap T sequence with a floating Spey or double taper — anchor placement scoring
- Snap T vs. Snap C comparison: cast both from the same position — student describes the differences in feel and anchor placement
- Heavy fly simulation: clip a large streamer-weight fly (or similar weight) — Snap T to lift it cleanly from the water

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

6	Spey	**Single Spey — The Touch-and-Go Upstream Wind Cast**	45 min

CUE

KEY CUE

- Touch — and — go. The anchor sets, you feel it, you go. Too early: crack. Too late: mud.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Single Spey is an upstream wind cast — the anchor lands upstream of the caster, the D-loop forms on the upstream side, and the wind assists rather than fights the cast. In a downstream wind, the Single Spey is dangerous — the fly blows toward the caster
- Touch-and-go anchor: unlike the sustained anchor casts (Snap T, Double Spey), the Single Spey uses a brief, momentary anchor — the fly touches down and the forward cast begins before the anchor has time to fully sink. Timing is everything
- The lift: slow and deliberate. The rod tip rises straight up, peeling the line from the water without splashing or disturbing the surface. The lift releases the water tension that would otherwise fight the direction change
- The change of direction: the rod sweeps in a smooth arc from directly downstream to upstream — a single, continuous movement with the body rotating and the arms following. The tip climbs at 45 degrees throughout the sweep
- The anchor set: as the sweep completes, the fly and 3–4 feet of leader drop to the water just ahead of the caster's feet, at an angle to the target. This is the D-loop position — the anchor is set

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Slow-motion Single Spey: each phase in complete slow motion — lift, sweep, anchor set, pause, forward roll. Instructor counts each phase
- Anchor placement only: practice the lift and sweep repeatedly without completing the forward cast — isolate and perfect the anchor placement
- Touch-and-go timing: student casts and identifies whether they cast too early, too late, or correctly by feel. Partner watches and calls the timing
- Distance build: single Spey at 30 ft, 40 ft, 50 ft — observe how timing adjusts with longer line lengths

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

7	Spey	Double Spey — The Downstream Wind Cast	45 min

CUE

KEY CUE

- Two movements, then the cast. Upstream sweep, downstream anchor, D-loop, forward roll.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Double Spey is a downstream wind cast — the anchor lands downstream of the caster, and the D-loop forms on the downstream side. It is safer in downstream wind than the Single Spey because the fly always travels away from the caster
- Two movements: hence 'double.' First movement: the rod sweeps upstream (out-of-power body rotation) to position the line. Second movement: the rod sweeps downstream and the line is placed as a sustained anchor. Then the D-loop forms and the forward roll fires
- Sustained anchor: unlike the Single Spey's touch-and-go, the Double Spey places the anchor with a sustained landing — the line sits on the water during the D-loop formation. This makes timing less critical and the cast easier to learn for most beginners
- First movement detail: starting with the line downstream on the dangle, the rod lifts and sweeps upstream — the body rotates, the arms follow. The line begins to lift and arc upstream as the rod sweeps
- Second movement detail: the rod tip sweeps back downstream in a smooth arc, placing the line as an anchor in front of and slightly upstream of the caster's position. The rod tip finishes pointing downstream toward the intended casting direction

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Two-movement isolation: practice the upstream sweep and downstream anchor placement without the D-loop or delivery — perfect the two-movement setup
- Anchor placement scoring: mark the target zone — inside/outside/on target for each cast
- Double Spey vs. Single Spey comparison: fish both from the same position — student calls which wind condition each serves
- Full sequence: Double Spey from dangle to delivery, 10 consecutive casts with instructor feedback on each phase

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

DAY 2 — Steps 8–10 + Film Analysis

8	Advanced	Snake Roll — The Elegant Downstream Wind Cast	45 min

C U E

KEY CUE

- The snake never stops moving. One continuous oval from dangle to anchor. Never pause.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Snake Roll is a downstream wind cast — arguably the most efficient of all Spey casts because the line is always moving and the anchor is set in one continuous flowing motion from the dangle
- The concept: the rod tip traces an elongated oval or 'snake' shape — rising, rolling forward and over, then sweeping back and down to set the anchor on the upstream side. It is a single-motion cast: there is no pause between the roll and the D-loop formation
- Why it is so efficient: in a Double Spey, the line stops after the upstream sweep. In the Snake Roll, the line never fully stops — the momentum from the roll carries directly into the D-loop. A skilled caster can fish 40% more casts per hour with a Snake Roll than with a Double Spey
- The snake path: starting from the dangle, the tip rises, rolls in a forward oval, sweeps back upstream-and-down — the fly 'snakes' off the water and lands as the anchor. The path described is roughly a lower-case 'e' or an elongated oval
- The anchor: as the oval completes, the fly and leader drop as the anchor — slightly upstream of the caster's position and angled toward the target. The D-loop forms immediately behind the rod tip

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Oval pantomime: trace the snake oval slowly in the air without line — instructor watches for a true oval vs. a flat path
- Snake roll initiation only: practice picking up from the dangle and executing the oval — do not complete the cast. Focus on the fly landing cleanly as the anchor
- Full snake roll: complete sequence from dangle to delivery — 10 casts with coaching on the oval path and anchor placement
- Single-handed snake roll: using a single-handed rod and double taper, trace the 'e' path — demonstrate the single-handed application

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

9	Advanced	Flying A Cast — Casting in Confined Space (Jason Atkinson)	35 min

C U E

KEY CUE

- Capital A. The letter is the path. If you can write it, you can cast it.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Flying A Cast was developed by Jason Atkinson as a solution to a specific problem: Spey casting in extremely confined spaces where even the space required for a standard Switch Cast or Snap T is unavailable
- The capital A: the caster scripts a capital letter A with the rod tip during the casting motion. The two upward strokes of the A form the path of the rod during the setup, and the crossbar of the A is the moment of transition to the forward cast. The entire motion occupies a dramatically smaller footprint than any standard Spey cast
- Why it works in confined space: the A path is compact and largely vertical — it does not require the rod to sweep wide behind or beside the caster. All the line repositioning happens within the vertical plane above and slightly beside the caster
- The trigger for use: dense vegetation directly behind, overhanging branches at casting height, a high bank, or a narrow slot where the normal D-loop setup is physically impossible
- The mechanics: starting from the dangle, the rod rises on the left stroke of the A (out-of-power body rotation), the tip traces across the crossbar (the anchor sets as the line is directed upstream), and the right stroke of the A brings the rod to the D-loop position before the forward roll fires

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- A-path pantomime: trace the capital A slowly without rod — left stroke up, crossbar, right stroke down. Identify each phase
- Obstacle simulation: set up physical obstacles (cane poles or tree branches) to create the confined space — student must execute the Flying A to deliver the fly
- Flying A to target: in the confined space simulation, deliver to a target at 30 ft — accuracy maintained despite constraint

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

10	Advanced	Integration, Film Analysis & Personal Cast Library	55 min

C U E

KEY CUE

- Out of power: body. In power: arms. That sequence is Spey casting.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Film analysis: watching oneself cast — even briefly — produces faster correction than any amount of instructor description. The camera shows what students cannot feel
- Baseline vs. current: the before/after footage is the most motivating moment in a multi-day clinic. Students who cannot believe how much they improved are nearly universal
- The cast selection matrix: which cast for which wind condition? Single Spey = upstream wind, touch-and-go anchor. Double Spey = downstream wind, sustained anchor. Snap C/T = upstream wind or large direction change with shooting heads. Snake Roll = downstream wind, maximum efficiency. Switch Cast = no wind change of direction, short repositioning
- The Flying A = confined space, any wind. The fixed anchor (line tied to stake) is a daily warm-up tool for every session from now on
- Personal cast library: each student writes their cast-to-condition matrix in their own words with a note on which cast they find most natural and which most needs development

MY NOTES

DRILLS

- Before/after video: student narrates differences using course language — out-of-power, in-power, anchor, D-loop, commit & complete
- Cast selection game: instructor calls a scenario (upstream wind, fishing right bank, downstream obstacle) — student names the correct cast and executes it
- Personal cast library: written in session, instructor reviews and countersigns

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I can perform this cast and name which phase is in-power
- ☐ I can diagnose the fault if it goes wrong

MY SPEY FAULT LIBRARY

Identify your top recurring faults. Use phase language: out-of-power, transition, in-power, anchor.

Spey Fault #1

What it looks / feels like	
Phase where it occurs	Out of power / Transition / In power / Anchor set (circle one)
My correction	

Spey Fault #2

What it looks / feels like	
Phase where it occurs	Out of power / Transition / In power / Anchor set (circle one)
My correction	

Spey Fault #3

What it looks / feels like	
Phase where it occurs	Out of power / Transition / In power / Anchor set (circle one)
My correction	

QUICK REFERENCE — SPEY ELITE CASTING CLINIC

CAST SELECTION — WIND AND ANCHOR

Switch / Forward Spey	No wind or any direction. Single repositioning motion. Body rotation (out of power) then arm roll (in power).
Single Spey	Upstream wind. Touch-and-go anchor upstream. One sweep from downstream to upstream. Timing-sensitive.
Double Spey	Downstream wind. Sustained anchor. Two-movement setup: upstream sweep then downstream anchor placement.
Snap C	Upstream wind or large direction change. Commit (rise) + Complete (C arc). Anchor flips upstream.
Snap T	Upstream wind or heavy fly/sink tip. Rise straight, snap perpendicular. Compact motion for short heads.
Snake Roll	Downstream wind. Single continuous oval from dangle. Most efficient. Touch-and-go anchor upstream.
Flying A	Confined space, any wind. Jason Atkinson. Rod tip scribes capital A. Compact vertical footprint.

AL BUHR'S IN-POWER / OUT-OF-POWER RULE

Out of power	No intent of loop formation. Body rotation drives movement. Arms follow. Used for: lifts, sweeps, D-loop formation.
In power	Loop formation is the intent. Tip path must be straight. Arm motion only. Body is stopped. Used for: forward roll delivery.
Transition	Body stops before arm motion begins in the power phase. Most faults live at this transition.

GLENDA POWELL'S WALTZ SEQUENCES

GLENDA POWELL'S SEQUENCE **1. LIFT** 2. CUT THE TREES (sweep — body rotation) 3. CLIMB THE BANANA (D-loop, anchor sets)	**CHRISTOPHER ROWNES' TIGER SEQUENCE** 1. GIVE THE TIGER A DRINK (rod tip to water) **2. LIFT** 3. PET THE KITTY ON THE BACK (sweep)

4. GO (forward roll — in-power arm motion) *WALTZ TIMING: 1 Lift 2,3 / 2 Sweep 2,3 / 3 GO*	4. CLIMB THE TAIL (D-loop climbs behind) **5. GO (forward roll)**

LEVER MECHANICS — TWO-HANDED ROD

Upper hand	Fulcrum — the point around which the rod is levered. Steering and direction control. Not the power source.
Lower hand	Lever arm — further from the tip, generating maximum mechanical advantage with minimum effort. Power source.
Push-pull	Upper hand pushes forward, lower hand pulls in simultaneously. The rod bends between these forces. Energy transfers to the line.
Single-handed Spey lines	Double taper preferred — distributed belly weight creates surface tension for anchor loading. Weight-forward taper insufficient for D-loop formation.